

Wrecks on the seabed

EVER SINCE PEOPLE TOOK TO THE SEA in boats, there have been wrecks on the seabed. Mud and sand cover wooden boats, preserving them for centuries. This sediment protects the beams by keeping out the oxygen that speeds up decay. Metal-hulled ships are badly corroded by seawater. The *Titanic's* steel hull could disintegrate within a hundred years. Wrecks in shallow water get covered by plant and animal life, turning them into living reefs. Aside from animals, such as corals and sponges growing on the outside, fish shelter inside as if in an underwater cave. Wrecks and their objects tell us much about life in the past, but archeologists must first survey them carefully. Objects brought up are washed clean of salt and sometimes treated with chemicals to preserve them. Treasure seekers, unfortunately, can do much damage.



VALUABLE PROPERTY

In 1892, divers worked on the wreck of the tug *L'Abeille*, which sank off Le Havre, France. For centuries, people have salvaged wrecks to bring up items of value.



SUPER SUB

The French submersible, *Nautilus*, recovered objects from the seabed surrounding the wreck of the *Titanic*. When the ship went down, it broke in two, scattering objects far and wide. Only a submersible could dive deep enough to reach the *Titanic*, 2.5 miles (3,780 m) down. With space for only three people (pilot, copilot, and an observer), they sit in a sphere made of titanium metal, which protects them from the immense pressure at these depths. Extrathick, curved plexiglass portholes become flat on a dive due to pressure. The journey to the wreck takes about an hour and a half, and *Nautilus* can stay down for eight hours.

Lights for video camera

Manipulator arm for picking objects off seabed

Less valuable silver coin

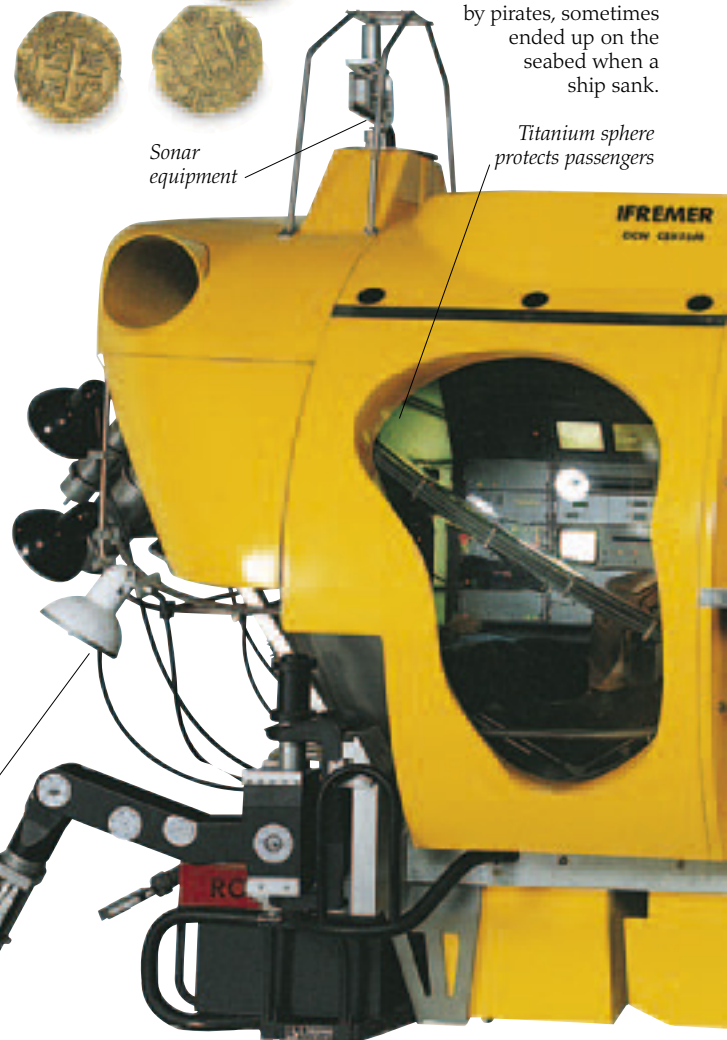


GLITTERING GOLD

Gold is among the most sought-after treasure. These Spanish coins, much in demand by pirates, sometimes ended up on the seabed when a ship sank.

Titanium sphere protects passengers

Sonar equipment



SAD REMINDERS

Many items recovered from the *Titanic* wreck were not valuable, but everyday items used by those aboard. Personal effects, such as buttons or just cutlery, remind us of those who died.



THE UNSINKABLE SHIP

In 1912, the *Titanic* sailed from England to New York on her maiden voyage. Because of her hull's watertight compartments, she was thought unsinkable, but hit an iceberg four days into the voyage. She took two hours and forty minutes to sink, with only 705 people saved out of 2,228. She was discovered in 1985 by a French-US team, using remote-controlled video equipment. The submersibles *Alvin* (US) and *Mir* (Russia) have also dived to the wreck since then.